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An intersectional perspective on disabled students' experiences in German higher education

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Abstract
The increasing number of disabled students in higher education highlights the urgent need to understand the multiple challenges they face, including persistent stigma, discrimination and isolation, which impede positive study experiences and academic outcomes. Adopting an intersectional approach to explore how disability intersects with factors such as socio-economic status, gender identity and cultural background, this study draws on data from biographical-narrative interviews with 33 disabled students from a single German university. The data is analysed using Straussian Grounded Theory methodology. Key findings show that disabled students often face financial burdens due to the inadequacy of public funding systems such as the German BAFöG, leading to experiences of stress and pressure to complete their studies. Those from lower educational or economic backgrounds report additional pressures as their families may not recognise the importance of higher education for an independent life, creating and exacerbating struggles with their working class identity. Gendered experiences, including 'medical gaslighting' for female students and fears of a potential 'loss of masculinity' for male students in accepting and disclosing impairments, further highlight the distinct barriers associated with societal ableism and gender. The study calls for policies that reflect these different experiences through inclusive educational practices, such as universal design, to reduce stigma and promote equal participation. It also advocates for the wider use of intersectional methodologies to more accurately capture and address the complex realities faced by disabled students in higher education.

Keywords Inclusion · Higher education · Disability · Intersectionality · Inclusive higher education · Diversity

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Background

The number of disabled students[1] in higher education is increasing worldwide. In the US, 21% of undergraduate students and 11% of graduate students report being disabled (National Center for Education Statistics, 2023). Similarly, the number of disabled students in Germany is currently at 16%, reflecting an increase of 4 percentage points between 2012 and 2016 and 5 percentage points between 2016 and 2021 (Steinkühler et al., 2023). However, this increasing percentage does not directly translate into positive academic outcomes and experiences for disabled students in higher education (Bartz, 2020). Research on disabled students in higher education clearly highlights the challenges they face on university campuses, including stigma, stereotypes, discrimination, negative faculty perceptions, lower graduation rates, and isolation (Gelbar et al., 2014; Hong, 2015; Markoulakis & Kirsh, 2013; Trammell, 2009). Thus, despite efforts to promote inclusive higher education, challenges and barriers persist (Ball & Tuckwiller, 2024; Bartz, 2020; Bühner, 2023; Buß, 2018; Steinkühler et al., 2023).

The higher education experiences of disabled students are shaped by a variety of factors, including the social environment and the broader higher education context (Nieminen, 2023; Polo Sánchez et al., 2018; Peschke, 2019; Salmi & D'Addio, 2020; Chiwandire & Vincent, 2019). Additionally, these experiences are shaped by the type and timing of the impairment and its intersection with individual characteristics such as gender identity, social and migration background (Brewer et al., 2023; Clouder et al., 2020; Creaven, 2024; Hamilton et al., 2023). Thus, disabled students in higher education represent a highly diverse group, with their experiences varying based on these intersecting factors (Abes & Wallace, 2018). Although still in its infancy, many scholars have begun to adopt an intersectional perspective when examining the experiences of disabled students in higher education. Vaccaro et al. (2020) showed that disabled women fear violence and victimisation due to their double marginalisation based on both gender and disability. Similarly, disabled African American students in USA report experiencing double disadvantage—originating from their race and due to their impairment (Banks, 2014). Further, Miller (2015, 2017) explored the complexities of the intersection of sexual orientation and disability on campus, and Killam and Castillo (2021) elaborated on the challenges disabled first generation students encounter in American colleges.

Despite the growing recognition of the importance of intersectionality, its absence in higher education policies and practices continues to be a recurring theme in research. Harpur et al. (2022) showed that universities in Australia do not sufficiently incorporate intersectionality into higher education policies, while Sépulchre (2023) pointed out the absence of intersectionality in higher education institutions in the USA and Sweden. Kutscher and Tuckwiller (2019) highlighted the general lack of intersectional perspectives on disability, and Nichols and Stahl (2019) emphasised that 'while there is a significant literature on disability studies in higher education settings, the field does not yet appear to have taken up intersectionality in a substantive way' (p.6). This may be one reason for the limited understanding of disability—or as Anne Shaw (2021) phrased it, the 'historical misrepresentation of disability'—that higher education institutions draw on when implementing measures of inclusion. Thus, developing an intersectional perspective on disabled students'

[1] Adopting the social model of disability, the article distinguishes between impairments and disabilities (Shakespeare, 2013). The term disabled students refers to those students with impairments who are disabled by the context of higher education.

experiences is necessary for both future policy development and higher education research (Kim et al., 2017; Liasidou, 2013).

This paper therefore adopts an intersectional perspective to further understand the experiences of disabled students in higher education, drawing on interviews with students who used individual accommodation at a German university. The paper conceptualises disability as a lived experience of oppression and disadvantage (Sommo & Chaskes, 2013) and follows the social model of disability (Shakespeare, 2013), assuming that there is a group of students with different kinds of impairments, such as but not limited to mental health conditions, bodily or sensory impairments or neurodivergence (e.g. ADHD, Autism), who share the experience of being disabled by the context of higher education. This facilitates the identification of intersections between disability and other aspects of diversity (McCall, 2005; Sommo & Chaskes, 2013). The paper's contribution to the field of higher education research is twofold: First, as far as is known, research into how the intersection of disability with other aspects of diversity shapes students' higher education experiences remains limited. Despite the fact that the present paper is only able to furnish a limited number of insights into the experiences of disabled students, due to the high intracategorical diversity amongst this group (Goldberg, 2016; McCall, 2005), it nevertheless manages to bridge some of the extant research gaps. Second, it contributes to the limited body of literature that examines the experiences of disabled students in German higher education.

Data collection and methodology

This paper presents an intercategorical intersectional analysis of biographical-narrative interviews (McCall, 2005; Rosenthal, 2018). The concept of intersectionality is rooted in black feminist theory to understand how multiple identities such as race and gender interact to produce oppression and privilege (Collins, 1993; Crenshaw, 1989). Although intersectionality originated in feminist activism, its application is not limited to feminism. Disability researchers have drawn on the concept of intersectionality in their work, elaborating on the intersections of disability with class, race and gender to understand how ableism produces disability identities and excludes people based on their identities, bodies and abilities (Marom & McNeney, 2024; Sépulchre, 2023; Kim et al., 2017; Liasidou, 2013; Sommo & Chaskes, 2013; Gerschick, 2000). From a theoretical and political standpoint, this paper conceptualises disability in accordance with the social model of disability. The social model of disability distinguishes between impairment—a bodily or mental condition—and disability—oppression and disadvantage experienced due to the social environment (Shakespeare, 2013). Therefore, in line with the United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (UNCRPD), it is argued that disabled students face unnecessary disadvantages in higher education, which could and should be mitigated by modifying the prevailing structure of higher education.

Adopting a Grounded Theory approach, the analysis treats disability as a lived experience, rejecting understandings of disability that are solely based on diagnoses or identity (Sommo & Chaskes, 2013). However, as the study focuses on those who received individual accommodations, the students had to be diagnosed with an impairment to 'prove' their need for accommodations. Furthermore, viewing disability as a lived experience does not necessitate that students identify as disabled. As the analysis of the interviews showed, identifying as disabled follows a rather strict social code, which usually defines disabled people as individuals with a recognised legal disability and/or a visible physical or sensory

impairment. Still, some students discussed their own identity and reflected on the social construction of disability in society and higher education and its effects on their experiences of exclusion. The 'Disabled students' experiences in higher education' section will elaborate further on this complexity, while the 'Discussion' section will discuss the analysis in the context of treating disability as a lived experience when adopting an intersectional approach to students' experiences of disability.

The analysis is based on the data collected through the SuccessInclusive ('ErfolgInklusiv') research project funded by the German Federal Ministry of Education and Research. The study was approved by the Ethics Commission of the Faculty of Social Sciences at the University where the project was conducted (Nr. E05202201). The research team interviewed 33 disabled students who were attending the university included in the study. Of the students, 17 identified as male, 15 as female and one as transgender. The students experienced a wide range of visible, invisible, physical and mental impairments, which they described as disability, chronic illness, mental illness, learning disorder or neurodivergence. Except for three, all students used individual accommodation at the time of the interview. Individual accommodation in Germany is institutionalised in the form of 'disadvantage compensation' and follows the idea of 'reasonable accommodation' demanded by the UNCRPD. It is usually granted as an individual assessment accommodation but can also be used to improve grades during the application process (Gattermann-Kasper & Peschke, 2023). While there are international differences regarding the organisation of accommodations, facilitating inclusion by granting individual accommodation is a common and shared practice in higher education worldwide (Marom & McNeney, 2024; Creaven et al., 2024; Brewer et al., 2023; Hamilton et al., 2023; Nieminen, 2023). To be eligible for accommodations, students must provide medical evidence of their impairment. Focussing on students using individual accommodations limits the sample to students with documented impairments and excludes students who did not claim their right to reasonable accommodation. Previous research has shown that only about one-fifth of disabled students in Germany utilise individual accommodation (Steinkühler et al., 2023). Simultaneously, focussing on those who used accommodations enables the recruitment of students who do not necessarily identify as 'disabled', as no reference to any identities was necessary during the recruitment process. This provides valuable insights into the diverse experiences of disabled students and the heterogeneity within this group.

To ensure maximum openness, the interviews followed a narrative approach (Rosenthal, 2018; Schütze, 1983). All interviews were conducted in German language by a white cis-male team member, who was trained in interviewing and is experienced in dealing with potentially traumatic topics. During the interviews the interviewer tried to create an open and safe space for the interviewees, ensuring a judgement-free environment (Loch, 2008). Many interviewees expressed that they felt understood and that the interview experience was pleasant and comfortable; none reported any experiences to the contrary. The interviews were transcribed verbatim and coded digitally. For this publication, some parts of the interviews were translated into English language by the author. The research was conducted using the Straussian Grounded Theory, characterised by systematic coding procedures and theoretical sampling (Corbin & Strauss, 2015). The analysis aimed to reconstruct the lived experiences of disabled students, with a particular focus on the mechanisms and processes that shaped their experiences in higher education. Initial interviews were used to develop an open coding system, which was continuously revised and refined through constant comparison. As the analysis progressed, and after approximately two thirds of the interviews had been coded, no new conceptual categories emerged, indicating theoretical saturation. The remaining interviews were then used to elaborate and

differentiate the emerging concepts in terms of their properties and dimensions, in line with the principles of axial and selective coding. Based on the analysis, intersections of disability with the economic, educational, and cultural background, and gender were identified. To gain a deeper understanding of the intersections, the investigation relied on previous research to further elaborate on the mechanisms and processes, as detailed in the following section.

Disabled students' experiences in higher education

This section presents the experiences of disabled students in the sample, focussing on the intersections of disability with economic background, educational background, culture and gender. As previous research has shown, first-generation students have access to fewer financial resources, have smaller and less diverse social networks, are more often dependent on state funding (BAFöG) and struggle with their working-class identity (Kroher et al., 2023; Spiegler & Bednarek, 2013; Wittner & Kauffeld, 2023). Thus, the 'Disability x economic background: the problem of lacking financial resources' and 'Disability x educational background: the struggle of overcoming the working-class identity' sections explore two aspects of class that are relevant to the study experience of disabled students: financial resources and working-class identity. In their intersection with disability, both create unique situations and influence the higher education experience.

The 'Disability x culture: mental illness, dsclosure and stigmatisation' section explores the relevance of culture to disabled students' experiences. Students grow up and live in a social context that is shaped by cultural understandings of normality (Mohamed & Shefer, 2015). Thus, impairments and disabilities are always experienced in an environment shaped by internalised knowledge and the surrounding culture. Even though students referred to specific cultures to explain experiences of stigmatisation and exclusion, research rather supports the thesis that stigmatisation and exclusion of disabled people, especially those with mental health problems, seem to be a common problem worldwide (Cheon & Chiao, 2012; Gronholm & Eaton, 2020).

Finally, the social construction of gender shapes the expectations and stereotypes that disabled students encounter from others and internalise themselves (Gerschick, 2000; Mohamed & Shefer, 2015). Previous research has highlighted this aspect by arguing that men negotiate the disclosure of their impairments in the context of the construction and loss of their 'masculinity' (Banks, 2014; Barrett, 2014; Gerschick & Miller, 1995; Shuttleworth et al., 2012). Women, on the other hand, are more likely to struggle with not being taken seriously by medical professionals and others, which can lead to late or missed diagnoses, self-doubt and mistreatment (Khan et al., 2024; Leece, 2023), a phenomenon known as 'medical gaslighting', as one interviewee explained (Sebring, 2021; Sweet, 2019). As discussed in the 'Disability x gender: diagnosis, doubts and medical gaslighting' section, these earlier findings are consistent with what was found in the data.

Disability x economic background: the problem of lacking financial resources

Financial resources are particularly important for disabled students. Previous research has shown that disabled students are more likely to report financial problems and take longer to complete their studies than non-disabled students (Killam & Castillo, 2021; Steinkühler et al., 2023). In the interviews, students described managing their medical condition

as time-consuming and energy-intensive, often leaving them with less time available for studying. Especially when suddenly experiencing impairments or living with a variable impairment, students need time to develop effective work strategies and navigate their individual situation. Additionally, students who had regular doctor's visits or attended therapy or rehabilitation programmes emphasised how much time and energy these tasks required.

> So, if I now look at my desk here. I have something here; I have an occupational disability insurance policy […] that's the next case. I have a request from the pension insurance company here. The next case is to be answered there. I have a prescription from the [doctor] here. I have a referral slip for the MRI. These are all forms. So, for one of those I have to go to the doc, he has to issue it for me, I have to go to the MRI. These are all things. Typical disability issues and then, on top of the disability, typical bureaucratic issues. And the more bureaucracy there is, the worse it gets. So, I could actually hire a clerk just to take care of my bureaucratic issues. And then I would have the time and leisure to take care of my studies. The last three years of university, you could say, were almost only half-time studies. In other words, a half-time course of study. Because the other half of the day was taken up with A) my health and B) dealing with bureaucracy. Maybe even more.—Noah.

Thus, disabled students may need more time to complete their study and may not be able to work alongside their studies (Chambers et al., 2011; Soria et al., 2023; Steinkühler et al., 2023). Students who relied on state funding (BAFöG) expressed their dissatisfaction with the duration of the state funding.

> Extending the examination period [due to using individual accommodation] is not bad either, but in the end, I would have to get either less material or more study time for the preparation phases or generally a regulation that I can receive the [state funding] for a longer period of time; 30% longer or something.—Benno.

The reliance on government funding therefore created pressure for students to complete their studies within the standard time frame. This pressure was partly relieved by the sudden onset of COVID pandemic, which led to a general extension of the funding duration without further requirements. Lena, for example, took some time to recover from COVID and deal with the consequences, instead of rushing to finish her degree.

> [After my last exam] the plan was, okay, now I'll take two months to take a deep breath, because, I have to be honest, the pandemic was of course advantageous for [state funding] recipients because the standard period of study was extended. […] For me it was a case of saying okay, I'm not under any financial pressure for now. I can also recover from my [second COVID infection] and everything that's going on.—Lena.

Furthermore, the assistive technology needed for studying by some disabled students is only partly paid for by the state. The limited funding results in inadequate support for developing personal skills and work strategies. Jona, who lives with a sensory impairment that can be compensated through the use of technology, describes the lack of financial resources as one of the biggest barriers he had to overcome in order to participate in (higher) education.

> Over time, I was able to buy aids that I didn't have before, because you always had to pay your own share and so on. That wasn't possible without further ado because the health insurance companies didn't cover the costs completely. And that's why I men-

> tioned the difficult material circumstances. So, in that respect, that was always the biggest problem, because I have a practical limitation that can be technically compensated for.—Jona.

Disabled students from high economic backgrounds do not face these additional pressures. Mira, for example, emphasises the fact that she is not dependent on state funding and suspects that she might have dropped out of university because of her ADHD if she did not have the freedom to extend her studies when she needed to.

> I'm lucky enough to be fully funded by my parents. If that wasn't the case, I would probably have dropped out a long time ago and would now be doing an apprenticeship or something. So other people with ADHD who don't have such an economic background, I think they would have been out of university long ago. […] I didn't have to apply for [state funding], take care of those things or anything like that, none of that was ever an issue for me. And that makes it possible for me to study for longer and have a longer chance than others.

Nevertheless, receiving financial support from their families can make students feel dependent on their parents. This creates an obligation to invest in the relationship by talking about personal situations and decisions, and by asking for financial support when needed.

> I have the incredible privilege that my parents are paying for my studies. If I didn't have that, I wouldn't be able to study and I don't think I ever would. So, if I wasn't lucky enough to have my parents pay for it, I would probably be dependent on transfer payments for the rest of my life or at least for a very long time, because I wouldn't be able to study because there's no funding for me, because I wouldn't be able to get [state funding] and I could work part-time and you can't get [unemployment benefits] or anything like that during that time. And I would never get a job where I could make a living part-time. And I think the realisation was once again super strong for me that I'm still totally lucky […] and at the same time I think I've maintained a relationship of dependency. […] I'm now 30 and I'm dependent on getting money from my parents. Otherwise, I wouldn't be able to do this degree programme and I'm lucky that my parents are both civil servants and can afford it. But I'm also totally dependent on having a good relationship with my parents. If that wasn't the case, I wouldn't be able to study. Of course that creates a relationship of dependency.—Ella.

Disability x educational background: the struggle of overcoming the working-class identity

Ella emphasised the importance of obtaining an academic degree for disabled students to achieve a self-sufficient and fulfilling life (Liu et al., 2024). However, parents without an academic background may not be able to fully support their children in their academic journey as they may not perceive an academic career as possible or even desirable (Spiegler & Bednarek, 2013). Furthermore, students may lack emotional support and information about studying and employment opportunities (Killam & Castillo, 2021). In the interviews, students emphasised that schools also do not provide adequate information about labour market opportunities for disabled students. For Jona, the information he received from a Federal Employment Agency employee was inadequate—even though he had attended school specialised in disabled students.

> The school also made a great effort to organise career information days. There are various programmes offered by the employment agencies, which we also attended. But what I saw there made me rather disheartened. […] the counsellors were very uninformed about what people with any kind of disability actually do. […] they didn't really know their stuff. They probably just didn't have the capacity for it.—Jona.

Thus, some students struggled to develop a positive perspective on their lives during school—especially those living with sensory impairments. While social networks and supportive family members can help navigate these struggles, Jona's case illustrates how problematic the situation can be when students lack support from their family members and social networks. He experiences challenges both at home and at school because his parents reject education and 'the professors'.

> I always had an aversion to reading as a child. On the one hand, of course, that was influenced by my parents, because books were for the professors. That was also a kind of insult. So, at home, professor was a swear word, an insult from my parents. If I said anything that was somehow 'cleverer', in quotation marks, than what they said. Then it was back to 'The professor has spoken'.—Jona.

Thus, Jona internalises a rejection of education and struggles in school. However, instead of accepting his rejection and giving up on him, his teachers support Jona in what he describes as a 'sneaky' way.

> They were so sneaky in their support. They just realised 'We must support this young person, but he can't go home now and then say 'Yes, and I'm going to do my A-levels and all that'. I wouldn't have believed myself capable of doing that, because the risk of failure is immense. And if I had failed, the gloating and so on would have been certain.—Jona.

Over time, he realised that pursuing higher education might be possible, even though his parents did not consider it an option. At the same time, he understood that without a university degree he has no chance on the labour market with his sensory impairment. This led to internal conflicts.

> School sucked anyway, that's what my parents taught me. So that was the quintessence of what they taught me. And therefore, as I got older, the perspective became more like, school is the only way to change your life situation at some point. And it's lousy the way it was and actually still is. I'm still not living the way I would like to live. In other words, I'm going through the classic ascent through education. Advancement through education is an incredibly poor offer. But it's the only thing that schools can offer. If you're desperate enough, then you take up this offer. […] I already had a very dark streak as a child because I knew that I couldn't [use the impaired sense] well and that it would be difficult professionally. […] And in general, from what I've seen of society. […] It was a time in Germany when people from difficult economic backgrounds were very openly bashed everywhere. I couldn't articulate it directly, but it was the general mood. I noticed that […] I noticed this whole basic mood as a child and accordingly I was very, very disgruntled at school. Some teachers also tried to stand up to me. But of course I couldn't really take them seriously because they were teachers. They went to university, I already knew that. They earn really well. So, what do they want to tell me? And that was also a formative feeling throughout my entire school career, that

> I wouldn't actually have a really good future. In that sense. So, it probably came down to [signals 'suicide' with his finger].—Jona.

The fact that Jona mentions suicide as an option if he cannot find a suitable position in the labour market shows the severity of these internal conflicts (Lund et al., 2016). However, due to the extended support he receives at a school specialised in students with sensory impairments, he is able to cope with these challenges, finish high school and attend university.

> Of course, during adolescence, the question arose more and more: these people treat you in a very dictatorial way, they tell you what to do, but they actually have no idea about the world in which you have to exist. And it was also clear that with my [impairment] I couldn't become a tradesman or anything like that. Which they probably, they never said that, but they saw it as the ideal path. But it was clear to me that this ideal path wouldn't work. I must do something else. […] At the school I went to, they naturally attached great importance to the fact that the pupils had to deal with the impairments or illnesses they had and build up their own knowledge so that they could later explain it to other people. […] The advantage at school was, of course, that everyone had to carry their own baggage, so to speak, because everyone has some kind of [impairment]. So, of course, there was no bullying or anything like that, which would be stupid. Because it was clear to everyone, so to speak, that everyone had a vulnerable point. So that was normal. There was also a bit of bickering and stuff, but from other classmates who were at other schools. The mainstream schools. As they say, I know that they experienced bullying or something like that. Fortunately, that wasn't the case for me at school.—Jona.

For Jona, the specialised school and the 'sneaky' support he received provided him with the opportunity to pursue an academic degree. He was able to develop a positive perspective on education and his chances on the labour market. His case highlights the special role of schools and other institutions in providing information about the labour market opportunities for disabled people. Jona's experiences show a typical pattern amongst disabled students from non-academic backgrounds. When families do not see higher education as a possibility and fail to provide adequate emotional support and information about labour market opportunities, students may struggle to break away from their working-class identity. Fearing that their impairment will prevent them from participating in the labour market, they experience their position in society as marginalised and are unable to develop a positive perspective on their lives (Killam & Castillo, 2021). In the interviews, students argued that a university degree allows them to have jobs with greater flexibility, leverage their strengths, reduce their working hours while still earning sufficient income—and thus to live independently without relying on social benefits.

Although disabled students from academic backgrounds also struggled with fears of not finding suitable employment, higher education was an obvious and expected choice for them and they did not have to deal with issues of class identity. Furthermore, parents were able to provide information about higher education and potential labour market opportunities.

> For me, it was always quite clear: I'm doing my bachelor's and I'm doing my master's. I used to think, of course, I will write my doctoral thesis. As a little girl I thought that. […] That's not the expectation that my parents somehow have of me. But I clearly grew up in a super academic environment. I think there are hardly any

of my parents' contacts who are not somehow academics. That said, it's still a kind of milieu thing, of course, that I automatically expected it for myself.—Mia.

Disability x culture: mental illness, disclosure and stigmatisation

Masculinity and cultural interpretations of normality can have a lasting impact on how students perceive their impairment and deal with experiences of disability (Banks, 2014; Barrett, 2014; Gerschick, 2000; Gerschick & Miller, 1995; Shuttleworth et al., 2012). The specific culture in which people grow up, and the knowledge they internalise, shape their perceptions of their own situation and the possibilities for action (Cheon & Chiao, 2012; Gronholm & Eaton, 2020). Vladi's case illustrates how cultural perspectives on mental illness can hinder an individual's acceptance of their impairment. Vladi was born in a post-Soviet state and moved to Germany with his mother as a child. From an early age he sensed that something was wrong with him.

I had known for a long time that there was something wrong with me. I read about depression when I was 14, and I knew there was something wrong with me because I always had this melancholy feeling and something. But in [post-Soviet state] they said you just have to stay strong (laughs) and nobody wanted to deal with it, it was a bit frowned upon.—Vladi.

Over the following years, he suppressed his mental illness and struggled with various symptoms. He felt persecuted, slept badly, developed anxiety and experienced panic attacks. During this time, he was hardly able to participate in university and when he did, he performed poorly. Finally, he realised that he cannot move forward without accepting his mental illness.

At some point, I also said to my wife 'I can't go on like this, I need help!'. She then made an appointment with a psychiatrist from one day to the next, […] where she then took me. Yes. […] I then went to the psychiatrist and immediately started crying. And when my mum found out that I was seeing a psychiatrist, that's when the family drama started. Then they started blaming everything on my wife and that she was to blame. That she had talked me into having a mental illness. That I wasn't really ill. […] My mum always put pressure on me […] and [my brother and I] were practically always her poster children. She didn't want to admit that I was ill. Not to this day. That my parents' divorce, that growing up back then. The collapse of the Soviet Union. Just all this shit where we grew up, that it had an impact on us and that we were simply neglected.—Vladi.

Referring Vladi and his brother as 'poster children' could be interpreted as reflecting a cultural ideal that men must be strong and courageous (Gerschick, 2000). It could also indicate that impairments—especially mental illness—are generally interpreted as weakness and therefore rejected (Cheon & Chiao, 2012; Gronholm & Eaton, 2020). In either case, Vladi knew that accepting and discussing his situation could lead to negative reactions from others—which he indeed experienced after finally disclosing his impairment.

While Vladi links his experiences to his culture, similar experiences were reported by Alex, showing that such ideals may not be limited to specific cultures, but may be present in the ideologies of many if not all countries. Alex was born and raised in Germany. As a young adult, Alex developed an anxiety disorder that became severe over time. At first, he was able to manage it well and began his career as an architect. He returned to university at

a later stage in his life and started his degree in a different field. When Alex started his education, the COVID pandemic occurred. As most of the seminars and exams were delivered digitally during this time, he was able to attend university without any major problems. When COVID ended, the university reverted to in-person teaching, which Alex found challenging. Alex decided to talk to his lecturers about possible accommodations. While some interactions with the lecturers go very well, others leave him feeling attacked, as one interaction shows.

> Last week there was actually [an employee of the university] sitting opposite me […] who I didn't know at all and who then said to me 'Are you undergoing treatment?'. And then I thought 'That's not possible. There's no way that's possible.' […] He says to me 'Are you in treatment?'. You have to imagine you have this illness, you're sitting opposite people you don't know anyway. You have to drop your trousers and say 'I have an anxiety disorder'. Which is already a certain threshold, because you don't get anything in return. […] That means it puts you in a strange situation anyway.—Alex.

Alex compares sharing information about his impairment to 'dropping his trousers' and exposing himself. Like Vladi, he views disclosure as a process that can change how he is perceived by others, often leading to stigma and exclusion. Thus, the stigma surrounding mental illness, the need to disclose their impairments, and the negative reactions from others create a situation where both Vladi and Alex experience barriers to higher education. While both cases suggest that (fear of) stigma may be linked to masculinity or specific cultures, the interviews revealed that the disclosure of mental illness is generally perceived as a challenge. While students implicitly refer to cultural ideas of masculinity and explicitly refer to an assumption of normality when explaining their fear of stigmatisation, it rather seems that ableism and the stigmatisation of mental illness are part of the common knowledge that all students are confronted with during their socialisation.

Disability x gender: diagnosis, doubts and medical gaslighting

Disabled women shared experiences of being doubted by others when discussing their physical or mental experiences, seeking medical support or even disclosing their impairment. One interviewee described the experinece of being systematically doubted and not receiving trust and support from medical professionals as 'medical gaslighting'. Medical gaslighting is a term that has gained recognition in recent years and refers to the experience – mainly of women – of being doubted by medical professionals (Sebring, 2021; Sweet, 2019). In extreme cases, the experience of medical gaslighting can hinder diagnosis and lead to increased self-doubt. In the interviews, students who had experienced medical gaslighting shared how they blamed themselves for the negative impact of their undiagnosed impairments which reduced their ability to cope with their situation.

> (Interviewer: You also told me about various doctors who told you not to make such a fuss. That [constant pain and fatigue] would just be normal. […])
> […] So I shouldn't make such a fuss, it's normal. At work, sometimes you go to work with the flu anyway, so if you don't have a fever of about 40 degrees, then you just take it. Everyone does, you go to work, you work. So I always say that the nice thing is that you just work. You don't put yourself out there and you work. Yes, but then of course I always doubted myself. I'm not a hypochondriac in that sense. But at some point I thought, 'OK, apparently I must be a hypochondriac,' because I said I felt the pain, I

> was miserable. But there was no one, […]. You can't compare it with others. It's possible that others have the same pain and also go to work. Because it's different with pain sometimes. And yes. […] As I said, the help I expected from a doctor or doctors was simply not available at the time.—Pia.

Even in less extreme cases, the experience of doubt can have a lasting effect on students' lives and study experiences (Khan et al., 2024; Leece, 2023). Kira, for example, talked about her difficulties in accessing study-related accommodation both in school and at university. She had to change schools several times due to a condition that is not common amongst people her age. Despite having a medical certificate, she only received accommodations in one of the three schools. When asked if she faced similar difficulties at university, she replied:

> The fact that I've already done that at two schools, that psychologists questioned me for hours, I don't know. I always felt a bit like I was being cross-examined in court. I thought it was kind of weird. I didn't even let it get that far at the university, so when [the person in charge] said 'no, we can't [grant accommodations],' then I was like yes, okay, but I'll leave it alone now. Well, I don't know. It always feels like I have to prove to someone that I'm really ill. And I've stopped doing that now, because I have no idea. If someone doesn't want to recognise that I'm ill, then they won't recognise it after I've proved it.—Kira.

Although Kira has been diagnosed now, she is used to people doubting her experience and therefore not receiving accommodations. This caused her to give up when she encountered this type of behaviour again at university. Thus, the appearance of a gatekeeper who doubts her medically certified impairment is experienced as a barrier to equal participation in the university and access to inclusion measures such as individual accommodations.

Both, the experience of generalised doubt and medical gaslighting can have a lasting impact on those affected. Students may internalise these doubts and blame themselves for not being 'able enough' which can drastically affect their health (Sebring, 2021; Sweet, 2019). Thus, after enduring a long period of medical gaslighting, receiving a diagnosis is experienced as a liberating moment, providing long-sought explanations. Mia is one such case. After years without a diagnosis, she was finally diagnosed with endometriosis. She has also been diagnosed with a mental illness and is considering seeking a diagnosis for her suspected neurodivergence. In the quote, she emphasised the need for diagnosis to better understand her behaviour, accept herself and receive support in the form of medication.

> But at the moment I believe that I don't need medication anyway and I don't need confirmation of my diagnosis [of neurodivergence] at the moment. That was super important for me in the past because I was never taken seriously because of endometriosis or adenomyosis because I experienced so much medical gaslighting. So it was really, really blatant. Both from the medical side and generally in my environment and a diagnosis was therefore relatively important for me. So I think it still is today in many areas, but with [the diagnosed mental illness] I've now somehow found an explanation as to why I am the way I am and can accept that, at least for now, and don't need anything else for the time being.—Mia.

Discussion

Adopting an intersectional approach, the analysis sheds light on the diversity among disabled students in higher education. It emphasises how factors such as gender, the economic, educational, and cultural background intersect with experiences of disability, shaping their higher education experiences. Discussing these intersections, this chapter elaborates on the different functioning of the categories and the question of additive and intersectional oppression/disadvantages before closing the investigation with four ideas of how to incorporate intersectionality in higher education policies. Reflecting on the methodology of intersectionality, former researchers pointed out differences in the functioning of categories referred to in intersectional analyses (Christensen & Jensen, 2012). These differences also emerged in the analysis. Based on the interviews, the category of social class is operationalised as economic background and educational background. Disabled students who lack financial resources experience disadvantages in higher education. They may not have enough money to deal with their impairment, nor enough financial security to take necessary breaks and extend their study period, while lacking the time and energy to work alongside their studies. Instead, they depend on state funding and feel pressured to finish their studies on time. Thus, financial resources shape the material conditions for participating in higher education, taking on special relevance for disabled students and favouring those who have sufficient financial resources while disadvantaging those who do not. Moreover, disabled students from a lower educational background must negotiate working-class identities and their own labour market chances in light of their impairment. This provides major barriers to participation in higher education due to identity issues. Jona's suicidal ideation clearly demonstrates the severity of these struggles. These examples demonstrate that social class functions in two distinct ways that shape the study experience of disabled students in terms of their individual resources and identity.

Analysing the intersection of disability and culture shows that culture primarily serves to define identity. The knowledge internalised during socialisation, particularly within the family and based on local cultures, shapes students' perspectives on their own impairment. This is reinforced by the actions of family members and friends, who (re)produce acceptance or stigmatisation based on cultural expectations of normality. The complexity of being confronted with and internalising cultural expectations of normality can also lead to identity struggles, a phenomenon that becomes even more apparent when considering the intersection of disability and gender. The cases of men and women in the sample demonstrate contrasting effects, both of which are rooted in societal heteronormativity—the norms and expectations that society associates with the assumed existence of only two biologically defined genders. While other researchers have already extensively discussed this (Banks, 2014; Barrett, 2014; Gerschick & Miller, 1995; Shuttleworth et al., 2012), the analysis shows how men feel pressured to perform a certain kind of 'masculinity', i.e. being strong, capable and independent, and how these internal pressures can lead to inner struggles but may also motivate individual actions. Women, on the other hand, reported the negative effects of being perceived as women in society, which results in them being systematically doubted, or, as one person phrased it, experiencing 'medical gaslighting'. This can result in them not receiving a diagnosis or medical treatment, and the accompanying social rights, such as a legal disability status or accommodations. Thus, while disabled men may experience identity struggles due to internalised gender norms, disabled women rather are denied access to medical care—and thus individual resources—due to their ascribed identity.

Furthermore, the analysis revealed that the category of disability functions in terms of resources and identity. Although the sampling strategy considered disability to be a lived experience, the students themselves raised the issue of identity during the interviews. Therefore, experiencing disability in higher education and living with an impairment can shape students' resources, experiences and identities in many different ways. Due to their impairment, they may lack the time and energy to study or socialise and may have to invest time and energy in medical appointments, rehabilitation, taking breaks from university or caring for their impairment. They may also struggle with their own identity and the expectations they confront themselves with, as well as with the expectations of others and their assumptions about what is normal and what is not. However, the analysis also hinted at the fact that the group of disabled students is highly heterogeneous. While the intercategorical intersectional analysis pursued in this paper requires referring to selected categories, an intracategorical approach would be fruitful to further investigate their intracategorical diversity (McCall, 2005). It is important to acknowledge the diversity among disabled students with regard to their resources and identities in order to avoid reproducing assumptions of normality and deviance. Nevertheless, referring to selected categories is necessary to analyse intercategorical intersectional experiences of disabled students (Collins, 1993).

However, this raises the question of whether the paper conducted an intersectional analysis or an 'additive analysis of oppression', as Patricia Collins (1993, p. 81) termed it. The problem with additive analyses is that they treat the different experiences of oppression as additive, resulting in a ranking of oppression. The intersection of economic background and disability could be interpreted in this way if the focus is solely on the financial resources available to students, for example in a quantitative analysis. However, when discussing the various functions of the categories, it was shown that an individual's economic background could have an impact on more than just their financial resources. The analysis actually elaborated on the mechanisms of oppression and the disadvantages experienced by disabled students because of this lack of resources. Furthermore, having a higher educational background and sufficient financial resources does not only come with privilege, but also new experiences of disadvantage, such as feeling dependent on one's family. The same can be said of the intersection of disability and gender, where the analysis identified unique experiences of oppression rather than a straightforward hierarchy of privilege. Therefore, reconstructing individual experiences and sense-making using qualitative methods, especially narrative interviews, is particularly suited for intersectional analyses (Sommo & Chaskes, 2015; Christensen & Jensen, 2012). Furthermore, narrative approaches allow students to share their life stories and hopefully empower others in similar situations.

Finally, the intersectional analysis sheds light on the changes that are necessary for higher education. As explained in the introduction, higher education policies rarely incorporate intersectionality. Based on the findings, integrating intersectionality into higher education policies would mean 1) informing students, and even school pupils, about their individual labour market prospects. This information must include a well-researched overview of the current labour market opportunities for all pupils in a class. Furthermore, pupils and students should be offered initial insights into the potential issues they may encounter due to their background, while avoiding the reproduction of stigmatisation. This may also require the systematic implementation of empowerment measures, such as inviting speakers with a disability who have successfully navigated their working-class identity. 2) In recognition of the material challenges of studying with impairments, disabled students should receive additional financial support to enable them to manage their impairments and studies effectively without compromising their health. Currently, German state funding (BAföG) does not adequately consider disability-related extensions to study periods;

students must apply for these extensions rather than having them granted automatically. However, recent policy changes mean that, from the winter term of 2024/25, state funding will provide an additional flexible semester for all students (Bundesregierung, 2024). While this may reduce barriers for many students in the future, disabled students in Germany still lack the opportunity to apply for a longer period of state funding and develop an appropriate study schedule (Janßen, 2025). 3) To reduce the stigmatisation and social exclusion of disabled students, universities should raise awareness of the diversity of human beings and of the high number of disabled students at university. This should be accompanied by serious initiatives to increase the number of disabled faculty members and to overcome ableism in academia as a whole (Capp, 2017; Killam & Castillo, 2021; Wilke et al., 2023). 4) While overcoming ableism is necessary, it will take time. Until then, universities should offer consultancy services that recognise the high diversity of students and the specific identity struggles of disabled students, which may be rooted in specific cultural understandings of normality, heteronormativity or ableism (Oexle & Corrigan, 2018), and ensure that individual accommodations are easily accessible (Pitman & Brett, 2022). Finally, universities should adopt inclusive practices such as universal design for learning (Cast, 2024; Grier-Reed & Williams-Wengerd, 2018), differentiated teaching (Jørgensen and Brogaard, 2021) and assessment for inclusion (Nieminen, 2022), to create environments where students with impairments can participate as equals without being disabled.

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Data Availability Due to the inclusion of personal and medical details, the interviews analysed for this study are not available in any public repository in order to ensure compliance with participant privacy and German data protection regulations.

Declarations

Ethical approval and consent to participate In accordance with the Helsinki Declaration, the participants were informed about the exact procedure of the study and took part voluntarily. All participants gave their approval. The study was approved by the Ethics Commission of the Faculty of Social Sciences at the University where the project was conducted on the 24.05.2022 (Nr. E05202201).

Conflict of interest The author declares no competing interests.

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